



Is Foreign Language News More or Less Credible Than Native Language News? Examining the Foreign Language Effect on Credibility Perceptions

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Abstract. In this study, we examine whether perceived news credibility is affected when reading news in a foreign language. In addition, we investigate whether a possible effect might be the result of (a) the attenuation of emotional responses in a foreign language and whether (b) it affects individuals depending on their need for cognition. In an online experimental study with $N = 134$ participants, we presented a news article either in the participants' native language or in a foreign language. Controlling for individuals' need for cognition, we assessed participants' emotional reactions and their perceived credibility. Results indicate that, for participants with a high need for cognition, the native language article was rated as more credible than the foreign language article. Participants with a low need for cognition perceived the foreign news article as similarly credible as compared to the native news. The language condition did not affect emotional responses.

Keywords: news credibility · foreign language effect · need for cognition · emotions

1 Introduction

Among many benefits and promises, online platforms, particularly social media platforms, enable an increasingly internationalized online news ecology, making news easily and instantaneously accessible across borders [3]. With the increased accessibility of and demand for international news, the internationalization of news readerships similarly expands. In Germany in 2020, for example, roughly 10% of the citizens consumed news in English (IfD Allensbach, 2021). Moreover, 54% of Spanish dominant Hispanics in the USA read news in English and Spanish (Pew Research Center, 2012), and roughly 27% Swedish nationals consume transnational news [41]. Especially migrants are likely to consume news in their native language but also in the language of the country they migrated to [1].

While the upsides of increasingly globalized online and social media platforms allow individuals to access and consume (international) news easier and quicker than ever before, one of the downsides is the amplified reach of misleading and false information [14]. Although news fabrication is not a new phenomenon [10], previous research of the last years connects online platforms with the increased dissemination of misinformation [40]. Consequently, individuals are increasingly challenged to decide whether news they encounter are credible or not.

In the light of both an increased international readership and an increased circulation of misinformation, it is important to ask whether reading news in a foreign language affects individuals' credibility perceptions. We argue that, in a first step, it is important to determine whether such an effect exists. In a second step, implications based on the direction of the effect need to be considered. Theoretically, two outcomes are possible: if news in a foreign language is more credible than news in one's native language, this makes consumers more vulnerable to misleading claims. In contrast, if news in a foreign language is less credible, factual information might be perceived as less credible, putting people at risk to discredit facts.

In particular, previous research on the foreign language effect (FLE) suggests that individuals process information differently when information is presented in a foreign language (L2) as compared to their native language (L1). Effects have been found, for example, for moral dilemmas [13] and risky choices [26]. Relying on previous theoretical and empirical insights on credibility perceptions and the foreign language effect, we investigate whether news in a foreign language improves or deters credibility perceptions about news.

2 Theoretical Background

2.1 Credibility Perceptions of News

Encountering information, individuals commonly assume information to be accurate and credible [20]. Explaining this initial accuracy assumption, previous studies point to higher base rates of true events, suggesting that in everyday life, most events are mundane and accurate [8]. Some research even proposes that individuals must, at least temporarily, accept information as accurate to comprehend the information [20]. However, under which circumstances do individuals reject information as incredible?

Applying dual-processing theories, such as the heuristic-systematic model [12] or the elaboration-likelihood model [38], suggests that two possible routes lead to the rejection of information due to a lack of credibility. First, individuals conclude to reject information based on thoughtful evaluation of its credibility. Thoughtful evaluations require effortful deliberation, which, in turn, requires sufficient cognitive resources and motivation. Second, dual-processing theories suggest that individuals rely on peripheral or heuristic processing strategies to arrive at the rejection of information.

While both routes offer theoretically plausible explanations as to why individuals reject information, empirical results by Metzger and colleagues [33] suggest that, instead of relying on effortful deliberation, individuals commonly employ

heuristics to judge the credibility of information on the web (see also, [31]). Several credibility cues have been identified, such as the source credibility [28], content coherence, consensus effects but also compatibility with prior beliefs and expectancy violations concerning the appearance of information such as professionalism or typos [29].

The preference of heuristic strategies over deliberative reasoning strategies has been, on the one hand, associated with a general information overload on the web [28]. In other words, due to the mere quantity of information, it is not feasible for individuals to engage in effortful deliberation whenever they are confronted with a new piece of information. On the other hand, previous research suggests that individuals often behave like cognitive misers, preferring heuristics as mental shortcuts to avoid cognitive efforts [16]. In doing so, heuristic processing can, in some cases, even match the accuracy of deliberate processing [19].

Despite its feasibility which can compete with deliberate processing, in the context of credibility judgements, it was found that people who rely more on heuristic processing were more likely to rate misinformation as accurate [37]. In contrast, Muda et al. [34] found that people who rely more on deliberative processing were more likely to rate accurate information as such. Going beyond correlational evidence, Bago et al. [4] experimentally manipulated the degree to which participants engage in deliberative processing by adding a cognitive load task as well as a time constraint. The authors found that deliberative processing significantly reduced belief in misinformation but did not increase the belief in accurate information.

To conclude, while individuals, by default, generally tend to accept incoming information, such initial credibility judgments are predominantly revoked by effortless, heuristic processing of credibility cues such as the credibility of the sources. However, given enough resources and motivation, individuals can also engage in effortful, deliberative processing to arrive at a credibility judgment. Furthermore, previous research indicates that reliance on deliberative processing can decrease the credibility of misinformation and increase the credibility of accurate information.

However, which factors influence whether an individual engages in heuristic or deliberative processing? In other words, what makes news more or less credible? Especially environments in which factual and false information is circulated, it is important to investigate news credibility questions and factors that affect perceived credibility. While some individual factors (e.g., individual differences in need for cognition), as well as contextual factors (sufficient cognitive resources), have been identified, in the following, we investigate a possible foreign language effect on news credibility perceptions. In doing so, as a starting point, we are mainly interested in the possible effects of a foreign language on factual news.

2.2 The Foreign Language Effect

The foreign language effect (FLE) generally refers to differences in judgement and decision making due to the use of a non-native language (L2). In different studies, it has been observed that individuals' decision-making results depend on

the language in which information is presented. For example, in three studies, Keysar et al. [26] found that when individuals were presented with information in an L2, decision biases were reduced compared to participants presented with information in their native language (L1). The authors suggest two possible explanations for this decrease of decision biases: increased deliberation and increased emotional distance resulting from L2 reasoning. Moreover, Hadjichristidis and colleagues [22] found that participants judged risks and benefits differently when information was presented in L2. Judgments became less risk-averse, and benefits were judged more pronounced. Testing the causal effect of emotions on the FLE, Hadjichristidis et al. [22] found that emotional responses mediated the effect of a language condition on risk perceptions. In particular, the authors found that displaying information in a foreign language decreased negative affect and increased positive affect. However, similar to Keysar et al. [26], the authors concede that increased deliberation due to L2 reasoning explains the results.

Investigating the increased deliberation hypothesis in more depth, Costa et al. [13] suggest in a theoretical paper that the disfluency of a second language increases overall deliberation. In other words, this disfluency explanation proposes that information in a foreign language signals that a person cannot rely on intuitive, heuristic responses, but that effortful deliberation is needed. Research on disfluency supports this view [2].

While there is empirical and theoretical support for the increased deliberation hypothesis, other studies examine the attenuation of emotion hypothesis in-depth. To that end, Caldwell-Harris [11] found, for example, that reading words in a foreign language elicited less negative affect. Explaining this result, Cladwell-Harris [11] theorizes that the most important factor which connects a language with emotional responses “is the context in which a language is learned and used” (p. 2). Using a language early on in emotional contexts creates strong associative pathways to the emotional regulation system. In contrast, a second language learned in a classroom has less association with the emotional regulation system.

However, both hypotheses, increased deliberation and attenuation of emotional responses, have been challenged. Bialek et al. [6] found, for example, that participants’ performance decreased when reasoning about logical syllogisms in a second language. The authors suggest that participants were less able to engage in reflective processing when information was presented in L2. In addition, the authors also propose a metacognitive approach to the FLE, arguing that the FLE affects individuals’ ability to either detect conflicting signals or stun reliance on intuitions. Similarly, results by Geipel et al. [18] challenge the attenuation of emotion hypothesis. In their experimental study, the authors found no differences in affective responses between two language conditions. Instead, Geipel and colleagues [18] suggest that the FLE results from decreased accessibility of social and moral norms.

Furthermore, some studies found no difference between information presented in L1 or L2. For example, the difference between L1 and L2 presentations were neither found in intertemporal choice paradigms [5], gambling decisions [35], nor for logical reasoning in the cognitive reflection tasks [30]. While both explanations,

the attenuation of emotions and increased deliberation as a consequence of foreign language use, are independent of each other, it has been argued that they can, of course, also cooccur [6].

2.3 Credibility Perceptions and the FLE

While the above-reported studies predominantly investigate the effects of a foreign language on judgement and decision making, central to this investigation is whether the FLE can also be found for credibility perceptions about news. First empirical studies investigating the FLE on credibility perceptions yielded mixed results. For example, Fernández-López and Perea [15] asked participants to read false news articles and judge the credibility and emotionality of the presented articles. Contrary to their predictions, the authors found no difference between news presented in participants' mother tongue and news in a foreign language. Instead, Fernández-López and Perea [15] found that emotionality drove credibility perceptions equally in each language condition, with higher emotionality increasing the overall credibility perception. Moreover, in a similar study, Muda et al. [34] asked participants to discern true from false news, which was presented in both participants' native language and a foreign language. Results indicated that the FLE reduced individuals capacity to differentiate true from false news by decreasing the credibility of factual news and increasing the credibility of false news. Similar to Fernández-López and Perea [15], Muda et al. [34] found that emotionally arousing articles were perceived as more credible. In addition, Muda and colleagues found that individuals' inclination for deliberative thinking increased credibility independent of language condition but did not interact with the language condition.

In light of these as well as previous results, different predictions about credibility perceptions can be made. As described above, individuals commonly rely on cognitive heuristics to judge the credibility of information, "minimize[ing] their cognitive effort and time, through the use of cognitive heuristics" [32, p. 214]. However, previous results show that individuals who rely less on such heuristic processing and more on deliberative processing perceived news as more credible [34]. In addition, both Fernández-López and Perea [15] and Muda et al. [34] found that increases in emotionality positively predicted the perceived credibility of news. Hence, we predict:

H1: Individuals' inclination for deliberative thinking affects the perceived credibility of news so that a higher need for deliberative thinking increases the perceived credibility of news.

H2: Emotionality drives the credibility of news, with news that are higher in emotionality are perceived as more credible.

Moreover, the increased deliberation hypothesis of the FLE suggests that, besides the trait level disposition to engage in effortful deliberation, foreign language reasoning should increase the state level of effortful deliberation in a way that individuals momentarily rely more on deliberative and less on heuristic processing. Hence, foreign language reasoning should increase the perceived credibility of news by promoting the credibility of news via effortful deliberation.

However, following empirical findings by Muda et al. [34] contradict these theoretical claims: foreign news was perceived as less credible than news in the native language. Because of these divergent predictions, we pose the following non-directional research question:

RQ1: What is the effect of a foreign language on credibility perceptions?

Going beyond the mere occurrence of the FLE, predictions can also be made about the underlying processes which lead to the FLE. As reported above, both Fernández-López and Perea [15] and Muda et al. [34] found that increases in emotionality positively predicted the perceived credibility of news. In both studies, this effect was independent of the language condition. However, these results contradict previous findings that foreign language reasoning leads to the attenuation of emotional responses. Because of these contradicting findings, we pose another non-directional research question:

RQ2: If an FLE for credibility perceptions is found, can it be explained by the attenuation of emotionality (i.e., lower emotionality of the foreign language condition)?

Reviewing the previous literature on the FLE, it remains unclear whether the FLE affects individuals differently, depending on their individual inclination for deliberative processing. To that end, previous empirical findings by Hayakawa et al. [23] and Muda et al. [34] suggest that the FLE affected individuals independent of their inclination for deliberative processing. Resting on the premise that reasoning in a foreign language increases deliberative processing, we hypothesize that if an FLE can be found, it should affect individuals depending on their inclination for deliberative processing. Credibility ratings of individuals with low dispositional levels of deliberative processing should increase due to the disfluency of the foreign language, signalling that reliance on heuristics is not appropriate. In contrast, credibility ratings of individuals with high dispositional levels of deliberative processing should be unaffected by foreign language reasoning as they already display increased readiness for deliberative processing. Hence, we predict:

H3: The effect of the FLE is moderated by individuals' inclination for deliberative processing, increasing credibility perceptions only for individuals with a low dispositional inclination for deliberative reasoning.

3 Method

This study received ethical approval from the ethics committee of the University of Duisburg-Essen. All hypotheses and analyses were preregistered.

3.1 Sample and Procedure

We applied a two group (native language vs foreign language) between-subject design. In an online experiment, we asked 134 (89 female) from the age of 18 to 55 years ($M = 24.93$, $SD = 6.56$) to read a news article in either their native language (here: German) or a foreign language (here: English). All participants were

instructed to read the article carefully. A timer was set to 20 s so participants could not immediately jump to the next page but instead spent time reading the article. Immediately after being presented with the article, participants were asked to rate how they felt after reading the news article and rate how credible they found the article. Participation was restricted to participants who were at least 18 years, had at least B1¹ skills of the foreign language, and whose native language was German. Bilingual participants were also allowed to participate if their second language was not English.

The news article was taken from a small local newspaper (Donaukurier) and discussed Covid-19 vaccinations. The original native language article was translated to English and back-translated to German to ensure the articles in both languages displayed the same information.

3.2 Dependent Variables

We used Gaziano and McGrath's [17] credibility scale to assess participants' credibility judgments, measuring credibility through ten items on a 5-point Likert scale. The scale's reliability was sufficient (Cronbach's $\alpha = .86$) so that items were summarized into one mean score, with higher scores indicating higher credibility.

3.3 Independent Variables

Emotions were assessed through the native language version of the positive and negative affect schedule (PANAS) by [9]. The PANAS consists of 20 items (10 positive affect ratings & 10 negative affect ratings), such as nervous, angry, relaxed, and enthusiastic, measured on a 5-point Likert scale. For the analysis, emotions were summarized into two variables, negative affect (Cronbach's $\alpha = .85$) and positive affect (Cronbach's $\alpha = .89$). Higher numbers indicate higher levels of negative and positive affect, respectively.

To assess individuals' inclination for deliberation, we used the abbreviated version of the Need for Cognition (NfC) scale by [7], consisting of 16 items such as "I enjoy cognitively challenging tasks". The NfC was measured on a 7-point Likert scale, with higher values indicating a higher need for cognition. All items were summarized into a mean score (Cronbach's $\alpha = .80$).

We also controlled for source credibility and language proficiency. Including a measure of source credibility helped us parse out variance related to the source credibility and enabled us to examine the distinctive effects of language. Hence, we measured in one 7-point Likert item how credibly participants rated the source (1 = not at all credible; 7 = highly credible). Similarly, we included language proficiency to account for possible confounding effects due to a lack of

¹ The B1 proficiency level follows the Common European Framework of Reference for Language (CEFR) (see more here <https://bit.ly/3mn129y>). B1 describes the independent user stage, an intermediate stage of language proficiency, which students commonly achieve after their graduation (after 10 years of schooling).

understanding. Proficiency was measured through one self-report item in which participants could indicate their level of proficiency (1 = B1, 2 = B2, 3 = C1, 4 = C2).

4 Results

To answer the overarching research question of whether credibility is perceived differently when information is presented in a foreign language, we conducted a multiple linear regression with perceived credibility of the article as the dependent variable and language condition (dichotomous variable), need for cognition, emotions and the control variables (age, gender, education, foreign language skills, source credibility) as predictors. The descriptive statistics of the dependent variable credibility and the independent variables can be found in Table 1. Results of the multiple linear regression can be found in Table 2.

Table 1. Mean scores and standard deviations of the variables of interest.

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Credibility	2.64	0.70
Positive affect	2.42	0.77
Negative Affect	1.58	0.58
NfC	4.83	0.74
Source credibility	4.05	1.26

Table 2. Results of the multiple linear regression with perceived credibility as the criterium, including the control variables age, gender, education, and foreign language skills.

	<i>Beta</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>	95% CI	
Language*	-0.165	-2.196	.030	-0.436	-0.023
Positive Affect	0.046	0.595	0.553	-0.095	0.177
Negative Affect	0.193	2.656	.009	0.064	0.438
Need for Cognition	0.075	0.994	0.322	-0.070	0.021
Source Credibility	0.510	6.546	<.001	0.197	0.367

Adjusted R² = .365, (F(9, 120) = 9.23, p < .001). * Coded as: Native language = 1, foreign language = 2

The multiple linear regression results indicate that, as predicted, the most significant contribution to the overall credibility perceptions was due to the perceived credibility of the source ($\beta = 0.51$, $p < .001$). However, after parsing out variance associated with the source's credibility, we found that language significantly affected credibility ratings ($\beta = -0.165$, $p = -.030$). The results imply that participants who viewed the article in their native language rated

the credibility of the article higher than participants who viewed the article in a foreign language, which supports previous empirical findings [34].

Furthermore, H1, which proposed that individuals' need for cognition would positively predict credibility perceptions, was not supported, indicating that credibility perceptions were independent of participants' need for cognition ($\beta = 0.075$, $p = -.322$), contradicting previous findings [4]. Supporting H2, the multiple linear regression results indicate that negative affect drove credibility perceptions-increased negative affect led to higher perceived credibility, supporting previous findings [15].

In a second research question, we wanted to know whether, if an FLE is found, it could be attributed to the attenuation of emotional responses. To answer RQ2, we conducted a parallel mediation analysis with model 4 of the Process Macro by [24], using bootstrapping procedures, computing 10000 bootstrapped samples with a confidence interval of 95%. The language condition was set as our independent variable, and credibility ratings as the dependent variable. Both emotion ratings, positive and negative, were entered as mediator variables. All standardized coefficients are reported in Fig. 1. Results of the mediation analysis support the findings of a foreign language effect on credibility perceptions found in the regression analysis. However, we found no support for the attenuation of emotion hypothesis. There was no indirect effect of language on credibility perceptions mediated by positive (beta = $-.06$, LLCI = $-.16$ & ULCI = $.01$) and negative emotions (beta = $.02$, LLCI = $-.05$ & ULCI = $.13$).

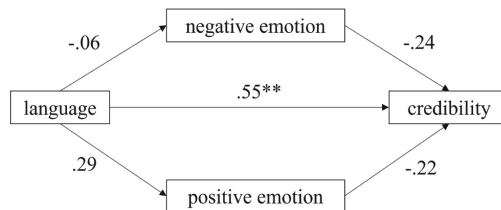


Fig. 1. Results of the mediation analysis with relevant path standardized coefficients. Significant path coefficients are marked as followed: *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$.

To conclude, while we found an FLE for credibility perceptions with the native language receiving higher credibility scores than the foreign language condition, decreased emotionality could not explain this difference.

Instead of the attenuation of emotions approach, another possible explanation for the found FLE is that the foreign language impacted information processing. We ran another multiple linear regression to test H3, which suggested that the FLE should affect individuals depending on their inclination for deliberation (as reported before). We added an interaction term of language condition and NFC (see Table 3 for the results).

First, when including the interaction term, explainable variance increased by roughly 4%. Second, the effect of language reversed, indicating that participants reading the foreign language article rated it more credible than participants who

Table 3. The multiple linear regression results with credibility as the criterium, including the interaction term of individuals' inclination for deliberation (NfC) and the language condition as well as the control variables age, gender, education, and foreign language skills.

	β	t	p	95% CI	
Language	1.122	2.456	.015	0.302	2.811
Positive Affect	0.032	0.462	0.671	-0.104	0.161
Negative Affect	0.205	2.903	.004	0.085	0.499
Need for Cognition	0.666	3.033	0.003	0.217	1.032
Source Credibility	0.508	6.712	<.001	0.198	0.364
Language*Need for Cognition	-1.434	-2.855	.005	-0.623	-0.113
R2 = .400, (F(10, 119) = 9.585, $p < .001$). * Coded as: Native language = 1, foreign language = 2					

read the native language article. Whereas the effect of negative affect remained the same (higher levels of negative affect increased credibility ratings), the effect of NfC was now significant. Scrutinizing the effect more closely indicated that individuals with a higher need for cognition perceived the article as more credible, as predicted in H1.

The results of the interaction effect suggested that the FLE affected individuals depending on their inclination for deliberation (NfC). While we predicted that the effect of language should only affect participants with low levels of need for cognition (H3), our results indicate otherwise: When information was presented in the native language, higher NfC scores positively influenced credibility perceptions. In contrast, when information was presented in the foreign language, higher NfC scores negatively influenced credibility perceptions. Moreover, Participants with low need for cognition differentiated less between native and foreign language news, whereas participants with high need for cognition differentiated more between native and foreign news.

5 Discussion

This study aimed to examine whether a foreign language effect (FLE) for credibility perceptions of news exists. Our results suggest that, indeed, news in a foreign language were perceived different than news in one's native language. The direction of this effect was, however, somewhat difficult to ascertain. While in the first analysis, foreign news was perceived as less credible than native news, a second analysis revealed that foreign news was perceived as more credible than native news. However, the results of the second analysis were dependent on individuals' level of need for cognition: the higher individuals' need for cognition was, the lower they perceived the credibility of foreign news. It was also found that the lower individuals' need for cognition was, the higher they perceived the credibility of foreign news. The contrasting effect was found for native language news: The higher (lower) the individuals' need for cognition, the higher

(lower) the credibility perceptions. The found interaction of the language effect and individuals' need for cognition contradicts previous findings by Muda et al. [34], who found no such interaction effect.

To understand these contradicting findings, let us first point to the differences between Muda et al. [34] and our study. While Muda et al. [34] conducted a within-subjects study design, our design was a between-subjects experiment. However, the choice of study design has been found to impact state processing. Stanovich and West [39] propose that within-subjects designs possibly increase participants' awareness of variables of interest. In turn, participants are more likely to decontextualize information presented, and more deliberative processing is cued, reducing the impact of naturally occurring individual differences. Hence, the null findings for the interaction of language and inclination for deliberation by Muda et al. [34] might result from the selected within-subjects design.

Another explanation for the observed interaction is that our results were confounded by a reduced understanding of the foreign language condition by people with a low need for cognition. However, because we controlled for individual differences concerning language proficiency, this explanation seems less plausible.

Instead, we suggest examining the effect of need for cognition separated by language condition. First, the finding that low scoring NfC individuals increased their credibility ratings for the foreign news article supports previous FLE findings. In particular, these findings suggest that, as a result of the disfluency cued by the foreign language, individuals who are less inclined to engage in effortful deliberation become more inclined to engage in effortful deliberation, which is reflected by increased perceived credibility of foreign news as compared to native news.

Moreover, findings for individuals with a high need for cognition yielded precisely the opposite results we anticipated. Because, theoretically, individuals high in need for cognition should be more likely to engage in effortful deliberation, we expected to find no effect of language. Instead, we found that the higher individuals' need for cognition, the lower they perceived the credibility of the foreign news article. This suggests that engaging in effortful deliberation undermined the ability to judge the credibility of the news article. We suggest that thinking too much might have negatively affected the perceived credibility of the foreign news.

Indeed, previous research has found that overthinking can affect individuals' judgement and decision making. Different explanations account for this effect, such as considering too many attributes or overweighting the importance of one attribute over others. Transferring these results to our findings, we suggest that foreign language reasoning could have resulted in overthinking for those participants who already show a high inclination for deliberation, leading to decreased perceived credibility. Alternatively, we suggest that the foreign language itself (in this case, English specifically) served as a credibility heuristic that was perceived differently, depending on individuals' need for cognition. Previous studies have already found that individuals differ in their attitudes about certain lan-

guages. For example, Kobayashi [27] found a gender effect for attitudes towards English, with Japanese females holding more positive attitudes. However, to better gauge the effect of individual differences in need for cognition and how such differences affect the processing outcome, future studies should focus on unpacking the underlying psychological mechanisms of credibility perceptions by focusing on information processing and elaboration measures.

Furthermore, the observed effects of emotionality were less ambiguous. Similar to previous results by Fernández-López and Perea [15] as well as Muda et al. [34], we found no effect of the foreign language on emotionality. Hence, it seems unlikely that the FLE for credibility perceptions resulted from the attenuation of emotions and was instead driven by the difference in information processing. Nevertheless, emotional responses shaped participants' credibility perceptions. The more negative the article was perceived, the more credible it became. This is in line with previous findings concerning the relationship between emotionality and credibility [15].

5.1 Limitations and Future Studies

Although we see good reason to assume that differences in processing depth are at the heart of the effects we found, we did not implement explicit measures of processing style. To ascertain a causal relationship, future studies should focus on measures and paradigms that allow to gain more insights into the processing style. To achieve this, previous studies have, for example, employed self-report scales of processing style [21], thought-listing [25], and perceived argument strength [36]. Affecting the general processing depth, the viewing time of the article, which was set to 20 s, cued more deliberate processing that would not occur naturally.

Moreover, as discussed above, specific attitudes towards the foreign language could have affected the perceived credibility. Hence, it is possible that high need for cognition participants perceived foreign news sources as generally less credible. To rule out the possibility that the foreign language itself served as a credibility cue, future studies should also include measures of perceived credibility of foreign than national/native news sources.

In addition, we would also like to point to limitations related to the selected stimulus design. First, while all text was translated to the foreign language (here: English), we did not change the source, which remained in its native language (here: German). Consequently, in the foreign language condition, it appeared that a native language source published news in the foreign language. Although two previous studies by both Fernández-López and Perea [15] and Muda et al. [34] used a similar set-up, we suspect that this discrepancy could have also served as a credibility cue which was only evaluated as a negative cue for participants with a high need for cognition. Solving this issue is not straightforward. One possible solution would be to choose a source that publishes in both languages, which must also be known by the participants.

6 Conclusion

In this investigation, we were interested in finding a foreign language effect for the perceived credibility of news. Showing participants news either in their native language (German) or in a foreign language (English), we found that the native language article was rated as more credible than the foreign language article. However, this was only true for participants with a high need for cognition. Participants with a low need for cognition perceived the foreign news article similar to the native news. Trying to explain these findings, we suggest that the foreign news condition promoted individuals with a high need for cognition to think too much (overthinking) which ultimately decreased the perceived credibility. In addition, we found no effects which indicated that the foreign language effect was due to reduced emotional responses. Although increased negative emotional responses increased the perceived credibility of the news article, this was true for both language conditions.

While our study does not allow us to make strong assumptions as to why we find a foreign language effect for perceived credibility, we would like to emphasize that the mere occurrence of the effect is, nevertheless, very important. As described in the introduction, the foreign language effect can possibly threaten news consumers in two ways by either increasing the credibility of misinformation or decreasing the credibility of factual information. As more and more people consume news in a foreign language, it is likely that negative consequences occur, like an increased belief in false claims or the rejection of factual information. Because the potential consequences of a foreign language effect can be very severe, we strongly encourage future studies to investigate the foreign language effect on perceived credibility in further depth.

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